example, liberals abstain from murder not because an ancient book or a modern constitution forbids it, but because killing inflicts immense suffering. Liberals find it deeply troubling and dangerous if people avoid killing just because “God said so” or because “the state forbids it.” People who are motivated by obedience rather than compassion might commit terrible crimes if they come to believe that their god or their government commands them to kill heretics, witches, adulterers or “enemies of the state.”

Conversely, if something doesn’t cause anyone to suffer, liberals do not see it as a crime, no matter what any god or government says. In medieval Europe, homosexuality was considered a terrible sin, because God and the Bible forbade it. But liberalism points out that when two men or two women love one another, this doesn’t harm anyone, so there is no reason to consider it a crime. While there are plenty of moral reasons to oppose violence, hate, and cruelty, what reason can there be to oppose love? In present-day liberal democracies homosexuality is therefore perfectly legal and acceptable, because it is assumed that human feelings like love are a higher source of authority than ancient scripture.

In a nutshell, we can say that the motto of liberal morality is “if it feels good – do it!” If people feel good about something, and it doesn’t harm anyone else, then it is good. Of course, liberal ethics can run into difficulties in situations when something that makes some people feel good, makes others feel bad. Is it ethical to levy high taxes on the rich in order to help the poor? The poor would feel good about it, but the rich would probably feel otherwise. Is it moral to launch a destructive war in order to remove a brutal dictator from power? It may save many people from misery in the long term, but may also inflict much suffering and death. And what about immigration – should we allow large numbers of foreign refugees into our country, who might take away jobs and services from citizens?

Liberalism doesn’t offer an easy answer to such dilemmas, but it does tell us how to conduct the debate. According to liberalism, all moral arguments should be couched in terms of human feelings and human liberties, rather than in terms of divine wishes or scriptural commandments. In liberal democracies even religious fanatics who oppose, for example, gay parades, have learned to argue that “it hurts my feelings” rather than that “God forbids it.”